

Questions to Ask Your Retirement Plan

A plan that survives these questions is worth trusting. Fifteen review themes, from tax and healthcare to what happens when one of you dies.

Use these questions when reviewing your own plan, working with the companion planner, or preparing for a conversation with a financial, tax, or retirement professional.

The best questions are specific. They should point to a phase, account, threshold, assumption, or decision.

1. Timeline Questions

- ☐ What are the main phases of my retirement?
- ☐ Which phase begins when I retire?
- ☐ Which phase begins when Social Security starts?
- ☐ Which phase begins when Medicare starts?
- ☐ Which phase begins when required minimum distributions start?
- ☐ Which phase has the most moving parts?
- ☐ Which phase is most sensitive to taxes?
- ☐ Which phase is most sensitive to healthcare costs?
- ☐ Which phase depends most heavily on portfolio withdrawals?

2. Income Questions

- ☐ Does each phase produce enough net monthly income?
- ☐ Which phase has the lowest net income?
- ☐ Which phase has the highest income?
- ☐ Does my income pattern match my expected lifestyle?
- ☐ Is my income front-loaded, back-loaded, or steady?
- ☐ How much of my income is reliable?
- ☐ How much depends on flexible withdrawals?
- ☐ Which income sources begin later?
- ☐ Which income sources stop or change later?

3. Income Floor Questions

- ☐ What is my essential monthly spending?
- ☐ How much of my income floor is covered by Social Security, pensions, or other reliable income?
- ☐ How much of my income floor depends on portfolio withdrawals?
- ☐ Does the income floor remain covered after inflation?
- ☐ Does the income floor remain covered if investment returns are lower?
- ☐ Would delaying or claiming Social Security earlier improve the income floor?

- ☐ Would an annuity or pension option strengthen the income floor?
- ☐ Which discretionary expenses could be reduced if needed?

4. Real Income and Inflation Questions

- ☐ What is my real monthly income in each phase?
- ☐ Does real income fall later in retirement?
- ☐ Is any decline in real income intentional?
- ☐ Does real income remain above my essential spending floor?
- ☐ Which income sources adjust with inflation?
- ☐ Which income sources are fixed?
- ☐ What happens if inflation is 1% higher than expected?
- ☐ What happens if inflation is higher and investment returns are lower?
- ☐ Does the plan still work if extended to age 90, 95, or 100?

5. Ending Balance Questions

- ☐ What is the ending balance in each phase?
- ☐ Which phase has the weakest ending balance?
- ☐ Does each ending balance support the next phase?
- ☐ Is the portfolio decline intentional or accidental?
- ☐ Does the plan leave too little for later retirement?
- ☐ Does the plan leave more than needed because spending is too conservative?
- ☐ What happens to ending balances under lower return assumptions?
- ☐ What account types make up the ending balance?
- ☐ How much of the ending balance is pre-tax?
- ☐ How much is Roth, cash, or taxable brokerage?

6. Tax Questions

- ☐ What is my taxable income in each phase?
- ☐ Which phase has the highest taxable income?
- ☐ Which phase has unused low tax bracket space?
- ☐ Am I staying within my target bracket?
- ☐ Does Social Security taxation change the effective cost of withdrawals?
- ☐ Would earlier traditional withdrawals reduce future required minimum distribution pressure?
- ☐ Would Roth conversions help before RMDs begin?
- ☐ Would a Roth conversion affect healthcare costs?
- ☐ Is the plan minimizing this year's tax while creating higher future tax?
- ☐ Are tax values current and verified?

7. Healthcare Questions Before Medicare

- ☐ Will I use ACA marketplace coverage before Medicare?
- ☐ What is my expected MAGI during ACA years?
- ☐ Am I trying to preserve premium tax credits?
- ☐ Am I trying to preserve cost-sharing reductions?
- ☐ Which withdrawals increase MAGI?
- ☐ Could cash, Roth, or brokerage withdrawals reduce MAGI pressure?
- ☐ Would part-time work affect healthcare costs?
- ☐ Would a Roth conversion create an ACA problem?
- ☐ What happens if healthcare premiums are higher than expected?
- ☐ Have I checked actual plan options and networks?

8. Medicare and IRMAA Questions

- ☐ When does Medicare begin?
- ☐ What Medicare premiums and supplemental costs should be included?
- ☐ Am I close to an IRMAA threshold?
- ☐ Could a Roth conversion trigger IRMAA?
- ☐ Could capital gains or large withdrawals trigger IRMAA?
- ☐ Will future RMDs create Medicare premium pressure?
- ☐ Would spreading income across years help?
- ☐ Is crossing an IRMAA threshold worth the benefit of the transaction?
- ☐ Have I verified current IRMAA values?

9. Account Order Questions

- ☐ Which account should fund the early retirement bridge?
- ☐ Should cash be used before taxable withdrawals?
- ☐ Should Roth money be preserved for later flexibility?
- ☐ Should traditional accounts be drawn earlier to reduce RMD pressure?
- ☐ Should taxable brokerage assets be used before retirement accounts?
- ☐ How much cash should remain as a reserve?
- ☐ Does the account order support ACA planning?
- ☐ Does the account order support IRMAA planning?
- ☐ Does the account order preserve future flexibility?

10. Social Security Questions

- ☐ What happens if I claim Social Security at 62?
- ☐ What happens if I claim at full retirement age?
- ☐ What happens if I delay to 70?
- ☐ How much portfolio withdrawal is needed to delay?

- ☐ Does delaying improve later real income?
- ☐ Does claiming earlier protect the portfolio?
- ☐ How does Social Security timing affect taxes?
- ☐ How does it affect a spouse or survivor, if applicable?
- ☐ Does health or life expectancy change the decision?
- ☐ Which claiming age fits the full plan best?

11. Roth Conversion Questions

- ☐ Do I have low-income years before RMDs begin?
- ☐ How much bracket space is available for conversions?
- ☐ Would conversions affect ACA costs?
- ☐ Would conversions affect IRMAA?
- ☐ Is there cash available to pay the tax?
- ☐ Would small annual conversions work better than one large conversion?
- ☐ Which phase is best for conversions?
- ☐ How much future RMD pressure is reduced?
- ☐ Does the conversion improve after-tax flexibility?
- ☐ What should be verified before converting?

12. Withdrawal Strategy Questions

- ☐ Which withdrawal strategy best fits this plan?
- ☐ How does my current plan compare with the 4% rule?
- ☐ Would Variable Percentage Withdrawal fit my spending flexibility?
- ☐ Would a guardrail strategy help manage market risk?
- ☐ Would a bucket strategy make the plan easier to follow?
- ☐ Should essential and discretionary spending use different strategies?
- ☐ Does the withdrawal strategy fit tax planning?
- ☐ Does the withdrawal strategy fit healthcare planning?
- ☐ Would I actually follow this strategy during a bad market?

13. Stress Test Questions

- ☐ What happens if investment returns are lower?
- ☐ What happens if inflation is higher?
- ☐ What happens if healthcare costs rise faster than expected?
- ☐ What happens if I live longer than planned?
- ☐ What happens if a major one-time expense occurs?
- ☐ What happens if part-time income stops?
- ☐ What happens if currency exchange rates move against me?

- ☐ Which phase fails first under stress?
- ☐ What change improves resilience most?

14. AI Chat Questions

If using the planner's optional AI Chat feature, start with specific prompts.

- ☐ Summarize this plan and flag the main risks.
- ☐ Which phase is weakest, and why?
- ☐ Which assumption has the biggest effect on this plan?
- ☐ Am I using low tax bracket space efficiently?
- ☐ Could any withdrawals affect ACA costs?
- ☐ Am I close to IRMAA?
- ☐ Would Roth conversions help before RMDs begin?
- ☐ Which withdrawal strategy fits this plan best?
- ☐ Suggest one conservative improvement.
- ☐ Suggest one income-improving change.
- ☐ What could go wrong with this suggestion?
- ☐ Which values should I verify before relying on this result?

15. Annual Review Questions

- ☐ What changed since the last version?
- ☐ Are balances updated?
- ☐ Are tax values updated?
- ☐ Are healthcare values updated?
- ☐ Are spending assumptions still realistic?
- ☐ Is the inflation assumption still reasonable?
- ☐ Has Social Security or pension information changed?
- ☐ Has my retirement date changed?
- ☐ Has my risk tolerance changed?
- ☐ Which scenario should become the new baseline?

Where to go next

Put these numbers to work in the AI Retirement Income Planner — it models income, taxes, Social Security, healthcare and withdrawals month by month, privately in your browser. Try the free demo at <https://airetirementincomeplanner.com/demo.html>.

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